

This page contains information to support assistance dog handlers, cruise ship operators and pet transport agents in understanding the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (the department) requirements for assistance dogs to travel on an international cruise vessel (a cruise ship) on a voyage that only travels between Australian ports. This page also contains information on the requirements for assistance dogs to travel to [New Zealand](#).

This information does not apply to:

- non-dog assistance animals (e.g. cats)
- companion animals
- any animal travelling on a cruise ship which voyages to Australian external territories
- any animal travelling on a cruise ship which voyages to international ports (any port outside of Australian waters).

These animals must meet appropriate import conditions in full. Please review the department's [step-by-step guides](#) for importing cats and dogs into Australia.

Information for assistance dog handlers

Before you embark on your domestic cruise, it's important to understand that some cruise ships are actually international vessels. This may mean different things for your trip if you are intending on travelling with your assistance dog.

Some cruise ships are domestic vessels which are either:

- Australian vessels which only voyage in Australian waters
- International vessels which have been '[coastally stripped](#)' and [released from biosecurity control](#).

Travelling on these types of cruise ships mean you do not have to consider any requirements from the department regarding this travel.

However, international cruise ships which remain under biosecurity control also undertake voyages within Australian waters. These vessels choose to remain under biosecurity control so they can offer passengers a range of international goods and products which they may not have been able to offer if they chose to coastally strip.

If you choose to undertake an Australian-only cruise on an international cruise ship with your assistance dog, you must be aware of the department's regulations and requirements.

To travel between Australian ports on an international vessel, you must be aware of the following:

- Your assistance dog must either be a resident in Australia or have cleared Australia's biosecurity import requirements upon import.
- You must seek approval from the cruise line before taking your dog on the vessel.
- You must not take any food off the vessel for your assistance dog.

- There must not be any other animals on board the cruise ship at any time, except for other assistance dogs that have boarded the vessel in line with these requirements. Speak with your cruise line to make sure you are aware of any other animals intended to be on board the cruise ship.
- The department can, at any time, determine that your assistance dog requires assessment or treatment. See [What happens if something occurs on my cruise?](#)

As of the 19th of May 2025, there have been [changes](#) to this process, and it may be different to what you have experienced in the past. The department published an [industry advice notice](#) on the 5th of May 2025 which details this change.

What happens if something occurs on my cruise?

As these international cruise ships are under biosecurity control, they have mandatory reporting requirements during their voyage within Australian waters. This reporting includes incidents which may require the department's attention. Some of these incidents may mean your assistance dog must be assessed by the department to consider whether the incident poses a risk to your dog.

Please be assured that while this is possibility, it's highly unlikely.

- An example of this may be a hitchhiker animal (e.g. rat) that was not identified on the ship's arrival into Australia. This hitchhiking animal would have an unknown biosecurity status and could pose serious risks to your assistance dog. The department may direct your assistance dog into our [post entry quarantine facility](#) to assess and manage any risks your dog has been exposed to. This may involve testing, treatment or an extended period in quarantine.
- Another example may be the emergency landing of the cruise ship at an international port. If you and your assistance dog disembark the ship, your assistance dog would lose its Australian health status and may not be able to be directly imported back into Australia.

We recommend you treat your assistance dog with a [compliant external parasite treatment](#) prior to boarding the cruise ship. You may also wish to consider arranging for your dog to have a [rabies vaccination and rabies neutralising antibody titre \(RNAT\) test before leaving Australia](#) so they are protected against rabies in the unlikely event your assistance dog comes into contact with an unacceptable biosecurity risk. These recommendations are not mandatory.

You must promptly inform the department if your dog develops any signs of illness during or following your cruise.

Travelling to New Zealand

If you will be travelling directly to New Zealand from Australia on a cruise ship, you must prepare your assistance dog for both:

[make contact with the Exports team](#) to ensure you get certification at the appropriate point in time.

New Zealand's Ministry for Primary Industries are responsible for the regulation of importing and exporting cats and dogs (including assistance dogs) into New Zealand. To enter New Zealand, you must prepare your dog for export from Australia in accordance with [New Zealand's import requirements](#) before the cruise departs Australia. Please contact New Zealand's Ministry for Primary Industries via phone on +64 4 894 0100 or email animalimports@mpi.govt.nz, as well as our exports team via phone on 1800 900 090 or email livestockexp@aff.gov.au.

Current advice from the Ministry for Primary Industries is that biosecurity clearances of assistance dogs travelling from Australia on a cruise vessel can only be completed in the port of Auckland. An assistance dog can only disembark the cruise vessel in New Zealand after the biosecurity clearance has been completed. Please ensure you consider this information when planning your travel.

For further information on the import process back to Australia, you can follow our step-by-step guide on [how to bring your dog to Australia from New Zealand](#). If you require further assistance, please call us on 1800 900 090 or email imports@aff.gov.au.

Information for cruise line operators

Cruise line operators must follow all legislated requirements and biosecurity directives. This includes reporting any biosecurity risks on the pre-arrival report as well as any changes during the vessels voyage within Australian waters. See [Vessels - DAFF](#) for further information and support.

Recent changes to travelling with assistance dogs on an Australian cruise ship

The department has recently reduced our intervention on assistance dogs travelling between Australian ports aboard these international cruise ships. See the [industry advice notice](#) published on the 5th of May 2025 which details this change.

Handlers of assistance dogs are no longer required to apply to the department for approval prior to embarking on their cruise and are no longer required to have their assistance dog inspected by a biosecurity officer when disembarking the vessel.

There have been no changes to cruise vessel reporting requirements.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/assistance-dogs/travelling-with-assistance-dogs-on-a-cruise-vessel>